

Europe's Security Council plan hits a wall of skepticism

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【メール原文】

Presented by Altana By NICHOLAS VINOCUR with GERARDO FORTUNA and GREGORIO SORGI GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in. In today's Playbook: — Eu

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GREETINGS. It's Nick Vinocur. Let's dive in.

In today's Playbook:

- Europe's €2 trillion budget battle plays out in dueling op-eds.
- The Commission is moving more EU officials out of Schuman — whether they like it or not.
- Faces in the crowd: Glenn Micallef, Carlos Cuerpo, Mette Frederiksen, Dimitris Avramopoulos, Christophe Hansen, Isilda Gomes, Friedrich Merz, Nadia Calviño, António Costa, Siegfried Murežan and more.

On this week's Brussels Playbook Week Ender: Carrie, Zia and Pieter join Sarah to assess Commission President Ursula von der Leyen's leadership on tech, climate and geopolitics in a disordered world.

****A message from Altana: Altana is the AI network where businesses, logistics providers, and governments are rearchitecting global trade. With Altana, businesses can prove compliance before goods ship and build more efficient, resilient, and secure supply chains. Logistics providers can automate the full brokerage workflow, and governments can promote economic security, manage borders, and enable the flow of trusted trade.****

DRIVING THE DAY

NOT ANOTHER MEETING: Ursula von der Leyen's pitch to launch a European Security Council is being greeted with profound skepticism in parts of the EU — including in Denmark, where Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen, touted as a potential leader of the council, has signaled she wants nothing to do with the idea.

The Security Council was a key point in the Commission president's State of the Union speech Wednesday, billed as a platform where Canada, Norway, Ukraine and the U.K. could discuss shared threats. It would be a safe space outside NATO at a time when Washington is often at odds with its allies.

But some EU officials and diplomats have responded with brutal feedback, telling Playbook that it would merely add more meetings to leaders' schedules without fixing problems of confidentiality in the EU.

"Can't see it coming to life in reality," deadpanned one senior EU official.

An EU diplomat riffed on Europe's seemingly ever-expanding list of discussion formats: "After Ukraine, Canada, Norway and the U.K. meet at NATO, they pop over to the European Council, grab a coffee with the Coalition of the Willing, join the UDCG [Ukraine Defense Contact Group], reconvene at the European Political Community, and then finally gather in the European Security Council to act decisively."

"Clearly," the diplomat added, "what's been holding Europe back on the world stage all these years ... [is] a shortage of meetings."

Unlike the proposal to offer Canada "associate member" status, this initiative didn't come as a surprise. European Council President António Costa pitched the Security Council to several leaders during a recent huddle in Finland, including Frederiksen. That fed speculation in local media that she could lead the group.

Which made sense: Tensions between Copenhagen and Washington over Greenland might make Denmark an obvious candidate for a group that doesn't include the U.S.

But a Danish official doused the idea, telling Playbook: "The Danish prime minister is very into all things involving security in Europe, but we are quite skeptical about this [Security Council] construction. Basically, we have a lot of meetings."

Another complaint: That EU meetings are ripe for eavesdropping. "The fact is that our defense officials don't feel comfortable discussing sensitive matters in EU formats," said a third EU diplomat. "Why would this be any different?"

The bottom line: EU diplomats can be harsh critics, especially when they're speaking off the record. But when even Denmark isn't interested — despite its interest in holding security discussions away from the U.S. — it suggests this could be another von der Leyen idea that struggles to become reality.

BIG AND BREAKING

CRUNCH TIME: German Chancellor Friedrich Merz is bracing for another brutal election result on Sunday — and for more questions about whether he can stay on as leader.

STEEL SCOOP: The Trump administration is quietly pushing to build a coalition to counter China's massive steel overproduction, even as it hammers those same allies on trade.

CANADA PUSH CONTINUES: European Investment Bank chief Nadia Calviño is heading to Ottawa to establish a bank presence in Canada and kick-start critical minerals projects.

FROM MFF TO PM? Romanian President Nicușor Dan has proposed MEP Siegfried Mureșan as prime minister — potentially taking one of the European Parliament's key budget negotiators out of Brussels

just as the fight over the Multiannual Financial Framework heats up.

EVERYTHING'S FINE: Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang is urging "responsible optimism" in the face of growing tech anxiety, reassuring wary crowds at King Charles' AI gathering yesterday that civilization isn't about to collapse.

Mark your diaries: Huang will join OpenAI's Sam Altman and Qualcomm's Cristiano Amon at a state dinner with Trump and Chinese leader Xi Jinping next Thursday, my stateside colleagues report .

FISCAL FACE-OFF

THE €2 TRILLION OP-ED WAR: Germany and Spain have turned to separate POLITICO opinion pieces to spar over the scale of the EU's next seven-year budget, setting the stage for fraught negotiations ahead of an informal end-of-year deadline.

EU governments are battling to preserve pet projects and curb the sums they send to Brussels. But after nearly a year of negotiations they're still a long way from a deal, Playbook's Gregorio Sorgi reports from Dublin after European Council President António Costa stopped there on his tour of 25 capitals yesterday.

The competing articles on our site this morning expose their widening differences:

Op-ed No. 1: Spain's Economy Minister Carlos Cuerdo argues that the budget should rise to 2% of EU gross national income, while proposing a delay to post-Covid debt repayments to release €11 billion annually for agriculture, defense and competitiveness.

"The next framework should have a ceiling equivalent to 2% of EU GNI — enough to support both the economy and society," Cuerdo writes.

Op-ed No. 2: Germany's Friedrich Merz and the leaders of Denmark, the Netherlands, Austria and Finland push back against increasing the budget, insisting that additional money and borrowing are not the solution. "We cannot just add every new priority to every old one and send the bill to taxpayers," they write.

The five countries are urging Ireland, which holds the rotating presidency of the Council of the EU, to remove hundreds of billions of euros from its next negotiating document — though officials anticipate there will be a compromise involving less severe cuts.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The U.N. General Assembly kicks off in New York next week. How does the European Union participate? Since 2011, the EU has had what's known as enhanced observer status. That means it can participate in debates, make statements and proposals, and address the General Assembly. Crucially, the EU can't vote, although all 27 member countries can, and the EU can help coordinate those votes.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

EU STAFF ON THE MOVE

EUROCRATS GO NORTH: More EU officials are set to decamp to Brussels' Northern Quarter after national capitals approved the rental of new office space earlier this month. That's unlikely to be welcome news for hundreds of well-heeled Eurocrats who are reluctant to swap Schuman for the gritty Quartier Nord.

Leading by example: The EU's own running costs have attracted increasing scrutiny during negotiations over the next seven-year budget, with EU governments heaping pressure on the Commission to save money.

The EU executive insists that it is tightening its belt. A Commission official said it is delivering on its promise to cut office space by a quarter between 2021 and 2030. Three EU agencies have already relocated to Boulevard Simon Bolivar in the Northern Quarter, with others set to follow suit.

The Belgian authorities have encouraged moving some EU buildings outside of Schuman to gentrify poorer neighborhoods. During a meeting of EU government officials earlier this month, the Belgian representative dismissed concerns around the Northern Quarter's safety, noting that several Belgian government departments are based there.

Cristiano Sebastiani, president of the Renouveau et Démocratie trade union, slammed the move north as "entirely unjustified." He told Playbook: "The health, safety and security of our staff must, now more than ever, remain the institution's first priority."

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

BATTLE OVER THE BAN: Ursula von der Leyen's plan to restrict kids' access to social media will require a whole new level of ambition to bring to life , Eliza Gkritsi and Ellen O'Regan report.

TRAIN HUNTERS: Russia is increasingly targeting Ukraine's railways , which are a lifeline for its troops, civilians and economy.

PRESIDENTIAL GAMBIT: Renew is leaning toward dropping its own bid for Parliament president and instead striking a deal with the European People's Party to stop it allying with the far right, Max Grier hears.

S&D MAKES ROOM: Top Socialists and Democrats lawmakers have approved expanding the group's leadership team to give an eastern delegation a senior post.

QATARGATE UPDATE: Greek lawmakers have lifted the immunity of former EU Commissioner Dimitris Avramopoulos after Belgian authorities issued an arrest warrant in connection with the Qatargate scandal .

CENTRISTS UNITED: As Carney fever rolls across Europe, Paul Dallison looks at the centrist dads ready to take on Donald Trump in this week's Declassified column.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals. High 21C.

UNWINDING AFTER SOTEU: The State of the Union week is tough on everyone — commissioners included. Luckily, two of them have found good ways to decompress ...

Plough on: Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen was in Tullamore yesterday for Ireland's National Ploughing Championships, alongside Irish Agriculture Minister Martin Heydon and, naturally, plenty of farmers. The three-day fair drew around 243,000 people, with competitors judged on everything from the straightness and depth of their furrows to the neatness of the finish. Bonus event: a brown-bread baking contest.

Sex, drugs and streaming: Culture Commissioner Glenn Micallef gets an altogether different post-SOTEU outing today: Hamburg's Reeperbahn Festival, centered on the city's famous nightlife and red-light district — and the neighborhood where the Beatles cut their teeth.

He's there on official business, obviously: Reeperbahn is also one of Europe's big music-industry gatherings and a showcase for emerging artists. Micallef speaks at the European Streaming Economy Summit on the future of music streaming at 1:45 p.m.

SAKHAROV NOMINEES: The S&D this week nominated the International Criminal Court for the European Parliament's Sakharov Prize for Freedom of Thought, saying it was defending the judges' independence from pressure by the U.S. Other candidates put forward for this year's prize include Tanzanian opposition leader Tundu Lissu (ECR); El Salvador's President Nayib Bukele (ESN); Israeli NGO Standing Together (Renew); and Palestinian doctor Hussam Abu Safiya (the Greens and Left).

SPOTTED ... at the speakeasy in Strasbourg on Wednesday night: Portuguese Socialists and Democrats MEP Isilda Gomes, who went on a night out to celebrate her 75th birthday ... and left shortly after because the bar was too crowded — the most crowded Playbook has ever seen! Time for a new watering hole. Ideas?

Also spotted ... at Acumen's Champagne-fueled shindig at KBR rooftop terrace: ePURE's Craig Winneker; CCIA's Albane Vannier; Disney's Thomas Spiller; EUCOPE's Matthias Heck; Fourtold's Victoria Main; Boldt's Simon Taylor; Euractiv's Josh Posaner, Thomas Moller-Nielsen and Magdalena Kensy; POLITICO's Mari Eccles and Dominic Giannini.

OPEN HOUSE, BRUSSELS: It's Brussels Heritage Days this weekend , meaning Saturday and Sunday offer that rare chance to snoop around places normally closed to the public. And if that doesn't sound exciting, trust Playbook: There are some gems, including private estates and historic residences such as Domaine Allard in Uccle and Domaine Tournay-Solvay in Watermael-Boitsfort.

The EU district pépite: Even the EU quarter has hidden heritage. The building housing Lithuania's permanent representation to the EU was once a grand private townhouse and later part of the Hôtel Dorlodot. It's been heritage-listed since 1993. Bad news: Tours are already fully booked, the embassy said on X . Good news: You can still look up next time you walk past.

A SECOND RAY OF SŪN SHINE: The EU Quarter's favorite Japanese coffee shop has opened its second location, this time in Ixelles. You'll find the same top-notch sesame lattes and cold brews. Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich writes in to report the tuna onigiri and katsu sandos are just as good, though the bowls can be a bit hit and miss. Open Monday-Saturday, but sadly, SŪN No. 2 is closed on Sundays. Rue Defacqz 24.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Finance Minister Lars Klingbeil and Friedrich Merz are haggling over how to fund relief on fuel prices before Sunday's crucial state elections.

Paris: Emmanuel Macron is summoning presidential hopefuls and party leaders to the Elysée to discuss global crises.

London: Chancellor John Healey heads to the EU finance ministers' meeting in Dublin , where he'll push for closer cooperation on defense.

Washington: Democrats see regulating AI as politically shrewd — but they're wary of the sector's money being turned against them in the midterms.

Ottawa: Former Conservative Prime Minister Stephen Harper has been sharing notes with Mark Carney on Donald Trump.

Canberra: Labor's migration plan has set up a fight with the Coalition over how far to cut and who'll get the blame for any damage to the economy.

AGENDA

— NATO's Military Committee Conference begins in Copenhagen. Welcome ceremony at 6:25 p.m.

— Eurogroup meets in Dublin, attended by Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis and Financial Services Commissioner Maria Luís Albuquerque. Press conference about 12:30 p.m. [Watch here](#) .

— Informal meeting of EU economic and financial affairs ministers in Dublin.

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič chairs an exchange with industry representatives on resilience and diversification; receives BusinessEurope President Maciej Witucki.

— Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera speaks at the leaders' dialogue during the 2026 Sustainable Development Goals Moment convened by U.N. Secretary-General António Guterres in New York.

— Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall delivers a keynote at the Clean Growth Summit — Road to COP31.

— Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen delivers a keynote speech at the inauguration of CCS project Greensand in Esbjerg, Denmark.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica has a phone call with Palestinian Vice President Hussein al-Sheikh.

— Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto participates in an EU enlargement event in Lecce, Italy.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Dolors Montserrat and Gordan Bosanac; former MEPs Fabio Massimo Castaldo, Elena Valenciano, Atidzhe Alieva-Veli and Dominique Riquet; former Washington Post reporter Desmond Butler; the Atlantic's Griff Witte; Booz Allen Hamilton's Valentyna Polunina; Iñigo Urkullu Renteria, former president of the Basque government; former U.S. Ambassador to Germany Ric Grenell; the Guardian's Chris Taylor.

Celebrating Saturday: MEPs Margarita de la Pisa Carrión; former MEPs Zbigniew Kuźmiuk, Jacek Saryusz-Wolski, Ian Hudghton, Jérôme Lavrilleux, Vladimír Maňka, Gunnar Hökmark, Robert Rochefort; POLITICO's Marion Solletty; former German Foreign Minister Heiko Maas; Managing Director and Chief Knowledge Officer of the World Bank Paschal Donohoe.

Celebrating Sunday: MEPs Chiara Gemma, Tomislav Sokol and Siegfried Mureşan; former MEP Mazaly Aguilar; the U.N.'s Katarzyna Rokosz; Aura Retail International Trading's Marion De Mattei; Competencia España's Cecilio Madero Villarejo.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Altana:** The rules of global trade have changed. Tariffs are tools of statecraft. Supply chains are leverage. And the old frameworks — built for a world of open markets and stable alliances — no longer hold. Policymakers need a new architecture. One that enables enforcement and trade simultaneously. One that lets governments collaborate across borders without compromising what's sovereign. Altana is that architecture. Our AI-powered network maps supply chains to the product level, verifying origin, process, and compliance before goods ever ship. Government agencies across the UK, US, Australia, and Singapore already connect through Altana to design and enforce trade and economic security policy — while businesses manage trusted trade on the same shared platform. The next era of trade won't be won by those who build the highest walls. It will be won by those who build the deepest trust. Visit altana.ai to learn how Altana can support your trade and economic security objectives .**

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